## BIDDING

Once the cards have been distributed, bidding takes place. Bidding is the most crucial part of the game as it determines:

i. the Player (the highest bidder is the Player) and the opponents (the partners);
ii. how many cards the Player may exchange with the talon;
iii. how many bid points the Player will gain – or lose – in the game (see Counting and Scoring).

The possible bids are as follows (in the order of increasing priority): Pass, Three, Two, One, Pauper, Sans Talon, Pauper *Ouvert*.

A game of Pauper is rare and Pauper *Ouvert* is almost non-existent in three-player tarok; most common bids are Three and Two, occasionally a One. The bids literally mean how many cards the player wishes to exchange with the talon. The better your hand, the fewer cards you need to exchange: accordingly, you should bid Three for a good hand, Two for an excellent hand, One for an outstanding hand, and Sans Talon for an exceptional hand. We will see later more specifically what these adjectives mean in practice. With a mediocre hand, you should Pass; or if you hold only low-value cards, one can bid a Pauper, with the commitment not to take any tricks.

The player to the right of the dealer starts the bidding, or says "Pass" if she does not wish to bid. Later we will discuss at some length when to bid and when to say "Pass". Proceeding counterclockwise, the next player must say "Pass" or bid; however, if he chooses to bid, he has to outbid the first player who has a higher priority. Similarly, the third player can say "Pass" or has to outbid any previous bidders. If two players bid the same, the earlier player has priority; in other words, the earlier player can match a bid to win it, but a later player has to increase the to win it.

There are three outcomes of bidding:
i. If only one player bids, and the others say "Pass", he is the highest bidder and becomes the Player. Once you say "Pass" you cannot change your mind and be reconsidered as a bidder!
ii. If more than one player bids, the bidding is continued (always counterclockwise) until all but one player say "Pass" or "OK".
iii. If all three players say "Pass", a special game called "Clop"[8] is played. Clop is a negative game: all three players subtract from their score their actual points gained in the game. It is for the fear of the Clop that one should THINK CAREFULLY BEFORE SAYING "PASS", when your cards are of borderline strength. Once you say "Pass" you cannot be reconsidered as a bidder! All too often, inaction will hurt your score: 35 points gathered in a game of Three can score as little as −10, whereas in a game of Clop, the same number of points is doubled and translates into a loss of 70 points (see Counting and Scoring).

A typical bidding sequence is as follows:

player X: Three;
player Y: Two;
player Z: Pass;
player X: Two[9]
player Y: One;
player X: OK.

Player Y is, therefore, the highest bidder with a bid of One.

Another example, when player X gives up sooner:

player X: Three;
player Y: Two;

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[8] The onomatopoetic word Clop may originate in *klopniti* in Slovenian or *klopfen* in German and thus may mean to knock (down). The modern Austrian term for the play of Clop is *Trischaken* (mugging), supporting this meaning.
[9] Counterclockwise, player X comes before player Y and has priority over player Y, so player X's bid of Two wins over player Y's

player Z: Pass;
player X: OK.

Player Y is the highest bidder with a bid of Two and becomes the Player.

On the other hand, player Y may give up if he feels too weak:

player X: Three;
player Y: Two;
player Z: Pass;
player X: Two;
player Y: OK.

Now player X is the highest bidder because she has priority over player Y. Player X has to be very sure that her hand is a winning hand, since player Y's bid of Two indicates that player Y thinks his hand is stronger. The bid should actually be made based on how many cards one would like to exchange (to get rid of a suit, for example; see *Exchanging Cards with the Talon*) and not so much on the desire to outbid the opponents. In this example, player X, if unsure of her hand, can instead say "Pass" and later, after the Player's announcements and before the actual game starts, say "Contra" (see *Challenges*), which means that Player Y's score will double – in the negative, hopes opponent X.

Jumps in bidding, though startling and rare, are quite possible:

player X: Pass;
player Y: Three;
player Z: Sans Talon;
player Y: OK.

Player Z is the Lone Hand because of his highest bid.

In general, long sequences of bidding are rare. Most often only one of the three players has a sufficiently good hand

(*vide infra*) to bid. If the cards warrant it, one should start with a high bid (for example, a One instead of a Three), as the bid cannot be raised once all other players have said "Pass" – which is very likely if your hand is so strong to begin with).

To determine the strength of your hand, for the purposes of bidding, check the following assets:

(i) the number and strength of taroks
(ii) the number of void suits and the total points of honors
(iii) the number of long suits
(iv) the number of cards in kingless suits

(i) The value of having lots of taroks in your hand is clear. Although taroks are "nulls" when counting (except for the Trio, which are honor cards), they are trumps and therefore the most powerful suit. The more taroks you have, the more powerful your hand is. If, in addition, these taroks are high (let us say, above XVII), you are that much better off since these taroks will not only win opponents' valuable face cards but also preserve your lead after a trick.

(ii) What one really wants in hand is as many taroks as possible and to be void of as many suits as possible (to have a chance of using taroks to gain entire suits from the opponents, which is worth about 13 points per suit). But, to be conservative, we will count only 5 points for each void suit (for a captured king, for example). The total value of honor cards in your hand is important because it is these high-value cards that bring the winning points (5 each, and one needs at least 36 points for a win). To have four kings in your hand may mean over 20 points (4/7 of a winning game!); however, kings may be captured by opponents with void suits, and so one cannot take these points for granted. The honors include the Joker and the Mond, which, in addition to being valuable, are also the highest taroks. Obviously, four queens (although they add over 16 points or 4/9 the winning game) are vulnerable by themselves, as they may be taken by kings, so we do not count them this estimate.

there are eight cards in each suit, one can theoretically play a suit at most twice before taroks are used by the opponents. Forcing taroks from the opponents is desirable, but here we are just considering how many value cards one can hope to bring home. Conclusion: at best, only the king and, with some luck (depending on the distribution of the suit among the opponents), also the queen of the same suit can be won.

(iii) But all is not lost: with a really long suit (4 or more cards of the same suit), one can keep depleting opponents' taroks and save the king or queen for the endgame, when opponents' taroks are exhausted. A long suit (4-8), can, therefore, for this estimate, be counted as having one additional tarok, which will draw down *two* taroks from the opponents, assuming that taroks are distributed equally among the two partners (a risky assumption!). However, these tricks will be lost, so you will presumably need a tarok to regain the lead, but that is a normal trick that may bring in some face cards.

(iv) The fourth item (the number of cards in kingless suits) is not an asset, but a liability. Both the bidding and the exchange with the talon must be made with this goal: ELIMINATE AS MANY KINGLESS SUITS AS POSSIBLE. The advantage of being the Player is clearly to be able to exchange three, two or one card with the talon and thus hope to obtain more taroks and get rid of some suits entirely. With this in mind, the number of cards in each suit in your hand is part of the decision on how much to bid. If you have only two cards in a kingless suit you may bid a Two instead of Three, hoping to exchange those two cards for taroks in the talon. Nobody can, of course, guarantee that the cards in the talon will be taroks, and a bid of Two instead of Three reduces the chance of obtaining more taroks. On the other hand, a Three increases the chance that one obtains additional undesired cards and suits, but also offers more choice in discarding undesired cards (see *Exchanging Cards with the Talon*). One really has to consider each hand on its own, and these generalizations are not as useful as the specific examples that will follow.

With this "grain of salt", the Decision Table on the next page is a rough guide on how much to bid when you have a certain number of taroks and a certain number of value points. It is very crude as other matters will be influential in each particular case (for example, the power of your taroks, the number of cards in each suit, as mentioned above, and the distribution of taroks and suits among the partners). It is only a crutch for the beginner; with experience, one develops an *intuition* for how much to bid, which becomes more reliable than tables, a feeling, which is actually a subconscious evaluation of all the factors we have discussed here. And even then, a bad talon or an unfortunate distribution of cards among the partners may ruin your calculations.

How to use the Bidding Decision Table

Possible winning points in hand are estimated by adding the values of the honor cards (5 points each), of which at least one should be a Trio member. For each void suit (*before* the talon exchange), add 5 points. Count the taroks and, for each long suit (4 or more cards in a suit) add 1 to the number of taroks. The intersection of the two numbers (points and taroks) is the suggested bid (sans = bid of Sans Talon).

# DECISION TABLE

| Taroks→ Points↓ | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 | 11 | 12 | 13 | 14 | 15 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 35 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 | 1 | 1 | 1 | sans | sans | sans | sans |
| 30 | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 1 | 1 | sans | sans | sans |
| 25 | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 1 | 1 | sans | sans |
| 20 | pass | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 1 | 1 | 1 |
| 15 | pass | pass | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 1 | 1 |
| 10 | pass | pass | pass | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 1 |
| 5 | pass | pass | pass | pass | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 | 2 | 2 |
| 0 | pass | pass | pass | pass | pass | 3 | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 | 2 |

**Three**

A bid of Three means that the bidder would like to exchange three cards with the talon. Whether to Pass or to bid Three is the most difficult decision for beginners. A rule of thumb is that with less than 7 taroks, one should "Pass", since that means that the opponents have, at best, eight taroks each! However, if your hand adds up to 20 points or more (for example, containing 4 honor cards), one can lose heavily if everybody else passes, and a Clop is played. In such a case, one would bid Three, knowing that it is a losing battle, but hoping (in decreasing order of probability) that the loss would be smaller than in a game of Clop, that another Player will bid higher, or that lots of taroks will be in the talon.

So, to bid Three, one should have typically seven taroks and at least 15 value points (see Table). These must be actual cards in hand and not "wishful thinking" that they will be obtained from the talon. This means one or two Trio members, one or two kings, or a void suit. In general, one should not bid without at least one Trio member. Otherwise, the (lost) Trio will cost the Player –20 points. With seven taroks, the ownership of the following value cards, for example, would make a bid of Three reasonable:

[J] [♡K] [♠K] or [J] [I] [♣K] or [I] [◇K] ♡–.

Ultimately, the number of cards in each suit may be the decisive factor in bidding. With short suits (one or two cards in two suits), one *can* hope to exchange them with taroks in the talon and become void in one or two suits (this is the main purpose of bidding). Alternatively, long suits act as taroks (since they will pull taroks from opponents' hands) and can be counted as such when considering a bid; of course, not one on one, as they will be mostly lost tricks.

Here are some examples of bidding decisions. All examples should be studied with actual cards in hand, which is more realistic and instructional than looking at the printed symbols. It is also more realistic not to know the other players hands. We also do not indicate whether the example

bid is the first or the last bid in the round; it should not matter, but if two players have already passed, the decision is somewhat easier, as one faces a clear choice: bid or be subjected to a game of Clop.

BIDDING EXAMPLE 1

[J] [XXI] [XV] [VIII] [IIII] [III] [I]
[♢1] [♢2] [♢3] [♣P] [♣10] [♣9] [♡K] [♠N] [♠7]

This hand has 7 taroks and 4 honors (one king and the Trio = 20 value points), but three kingless suits. One can hope to exchange one of the three suits with taroks in the talon, but unless there are kings in the talon (small probability), one will still be left with two kingless suits, which bring the opponents at least 25 points. The taroks are rather low, too. This hand is a borderline case, in which a bid would be a gamble, hoping that the talon has to offer some kings and taroks. So, unless the Player is lucky, this may be a losing hand. One has to consider the other side of the coin, however: in a game of Clop, this hand might collect about – 30 points (the Trio and all hearts), which is close to a (doubled!) loss, so a bid of Three is a better risk. In reality, the Player won this game on a bid of Three by a spread of 6 points. One less honor in the hand might have led to a small loss. Follow this game through Talon Example *1* (p. 36), Deposit Example 1 (p. 42) and Play Example 1 (p. 69).

BIDDING EXAMPLE 2

[XVII] [XVI] [XV] [XIV] [XI] [VIII] [VI] [V]
[♡N] [♠Q] [♠N] [♢K] [♢Q] [♢N] [♢2] [♢4]

The number of taroks (8 plus one long suit makes it effectively 9) and the adjusted points (10 for one king and one void suit) are low for a bid, especially with none of the Trio. However, the suit distribution makes a bid of Three ideal: the heart and spades can be exchanged, and the resulting hand with three void suits looks excellent, as long as the talon does not throw a wrench into the exchange. In

addition, the long suit of diamonds will use up opponents' taroks.

Follow this game through Talon Example 2 (p. 36), Deposit Example 2 (p. 43) and Play Example 2 (p. 74).

BIDDING EXAMPLE 3

[XXI] [XX] [XVII] [XVI] [XIV] [XIII] [XII]
[♡K] [♡P] [♡1] [♠8] [◇K] [◇N] [◇4] [♣N] [♣10]

Although this hand contains a minimum of assets for a bid (7 taroks and 3 honor cards, including the Mond), the taroks are rather high, and the suits are ideally distributed for a bid of Three (one can deposit both spades and clubs), as long as the talon does not spoil this plan. See Talon Example 3 (p. 37) for what happens next.

BIDDING EXAMPLE 4

[XXI] [XVIII] [XVII] [XII] [VIII] [VII] [III]
[♡3] [♠K] [♠Q] [♠N] [◇N] [◇P] [◇4] [♣K] [♣10]

With 7 taroks and 3 honors, this hand is again barely strong enough to make a bid of Three. However, the distribution of suits is favorable: one can deposit one suit (diamonds) and have a singleton in another kingless suit (hearts) left that could be used in a king bluff. See Talon Example 4 (p. 38) for what happens next.

As the number of taroks in hand increases above 7, a bid of Three is almost necessary as long as you have at least one honor card or one void suit, and as long as you can prevent (after exchange with the talon) having more than two kingless suits. Ten or more taroks demand a bid, no matter what else your hand has to offer, because a game of Clop would be more detrimental.

**Two**

The difference between a bid of Three and Two is greater than it seems. First, the game is worth three times as many bid points, so a loss of game is significant. Secondly, one

can exchange only two cards, which is a large handicap, so the hand must be strong to be able to afford such a small exchange. Thirdly, one leaves the opponents one extra card in the talon (four instead of three cards) and that could be worth up to 5 points. Lastly, if you are trying to outbid a Three that means that another Player has reasonably good cards and that the talon is not expected to be rich. So, a Two should not be bid with less than eight taroks. Even with eight taroks one should have at least 25 value points in hand (for example, five honor cards or four honor cards and a void suit). With each additional tarok or void suit, one can own one honor card less to still hope to win. With twelve or more taroks, a bid of Two is advisable almost regardless of all other factors. Generally, bid a Two if you have two cards in a suit or singletons in two suits, all other suits being void or protected by a king. An alternative is to let the bid of Three stand, and challenge the Player with a "Contra", based on your own good hand or a bad talon.

BIDDING EXAMPLE 5

[J] [XXI] [XVII] [XIV] [XI] [X] [VIII] [VI]
[♣P] [♣10] [♡K] [♡P] [♡1] [♠K] [♠P] [♠9]

This hand holds eight taroks and 25 value points (four honor cards and a blank suit of diamonds). The owner of this hand bids Two for the following reasons.

Eight taroks, including the highest two, demand a bid. Should it be Three or Two? The suits are very powerful: two are protected by their kings, the third suit (diamonds) is void, and one can get rid of the fourth suit (clubs), hopefully by a favorable exchange with the talon. If there were three clubs in this hand, a bid of Three would be the better choice. Since there are only two clubs to be exchanged, a bid of Two is reasonable. The two pages are bad as they will be taken by opponents' queens (giving them 10 points), so one could bid a Three to deposit also one of the pages. However, there is no guarantee that there will be three taroks in the talon; a bid of Two also reduces the chance of getting more undesirable cards from the talon (for example,

a diamond). A bid of Two allows you to choose from three pairs of cards in the talon rather than from two triplets, as is the case of a bid of Three. Follow up with Talon Example 5 (p. 38) to see what talon this Player gets and how the hand plays out.

**One**

A bid of One requires outstanding cards. Do not bid One with less than eleven taroks and 30 points in hand. With each additional tarok or void suit one can have one honor less to still hope to win, and conversely: for each additional honor card or void suit one can have one less tarok. Usually, bid a One when you need to exchange a single card, for example, a singleton or a pip card paired with a king, all other suits being either protected by a king or void. (See Game Example H, p. 138). If you are missing only a Trio member or the fourth king, bid a One, hoping to obtain it from the talon.

**Pauper**

When your hand is as lousy as it can be, you may consider a bid of Pauper. In this game you promise to take no tricks, and you lose the game (a flat score of –70 points) if you take even one trick. A Pauper (with three players) is a very rare bid, especially since Sans Talon has a higher priority; however, it can be won. The alert reader will remember that with no taroks in hand, one must call off the game; that means that a hand of Pauper will have at least one tarok. In this game, as in the game of Clop, one must top every card, if possible, while following suit. This is true for the Player as well as for both partners. The talon must remain unrevealed till the end of the game, when it is inspected to see that no rules were violated during the game (for example, to prove that a higher-ranked card was in the talon and not in the partner's hand). Clearly, the phases of talon exchange and deposit are omitted, but a challenge of "Contra" from the partners is common. A *Mondfang* or bonuses do not count in this game.

In a game of Pauper, the Player starts, regardless of whose turn it was otherwise. This means that the Player may have one high card and still hope to win, for example a queen or

a high tarok, which the Player leads with. The risk is, of course, that all the higher cards are in the talon. If in addition to this one high card, the Player holds a middle-rank card (let us say a page or the tarok [V]), then she also must possess all the lower cards in that (long) suit, otherwise a trick will be won with this middle-ranked card, and the game lost.

So, for example, if the Player holds a [♣Q] and a [♣9], she should lead with the queen, otherwise there is a danger that an opponent will lead with a low club, and the queen will have to take it. It will be painful, however, if the [♣K] resides in the talon or if none of the opponents is devoid of the suit, but such risks must be considered when bidding. Similarly, if the hand includes [♡2] and [♡P], one should lead with the [♡P]. As in a game of Clop, the players should quickly get rid of the highest cards that have even a chance of taking a trick.

In theory, one can even win by leading with the Pagat, but if both the Mond and Joker are not in the hand of a single opponent, the partners will immediately play both of these cards, and the Pagat takes the trick! This is too great a risk. A better choice with a singlet Pagat is to announce a Pagat *Vogelfrei* (see *Announcements*), after somebody else wins a bid.

After the game, three open bullets are drawn (as in the game of Clop) to denote that the score in the following games will double (see *Counting*).

**Sans Talon**

A bid of Sans Talon means that you have no need to exchange any cards with the talon. If you have all seven honor cards, you are not lacking anything: bid a Sans Talon. Do not bid One just to see the talon; what is there to gain if you hold everything? And a bid of Sans Talon is worth more than any one new card. The entire talon, however, belongs to the opponents and is hidden until the end of the game. To bid Sans Talon, your hand should hold at least 12 taroks, including the Trio, and all suits should

either include a king or be void, which means 35 points. If, in addition, all your taroks are very high, strongly consider playing a Valat (see *Announcements*) and set your strategy accordingly.

Clearly, if Sans Talon is bid, the talon and deposit phase of the game are omitted; however, any announcements and challenges can be made, for example, Pagat *Ultimo*, Valat, or Contra, before the play begins.

**Pauper *Ouvert***

This bid of Pauper *Ouvert* leads to a game with rules similar to the Pauper described above, except that the Player, after leading with his highest-rank card, lays his cards face up on the table. The partners can, therefore, study the Player's hand and play accordingly, but, of course, cannot consult each other.

This type of game is almost unwinnable with three players as it requires absolutely the lowest cards. Clearly, except for the one high card, with which one leads, one should hold no taroks and no face cards, or else, if one has a middle-rank card, one must also own every lower card in that suit. The one high card obviously should not be a king or a card of too high a rank, as the risk increases that all higher cards are in the talon! Void suits are acceptable, as long as there are no taroks left in hand. This game scores a flat ±90 points, with no bonuses, but it can be doubled by a Contra and/or by bullets.

After the game, three open bullets are drawn (as for a Clop) to denote that the scores in the following games will double.

**Pass**

If your cards do not support a winning game, say "Pass", and the next Player can bid. Once you say "Pass" you cannot change your mind in the current round. A winning hand requires a certain number of taroks, honors, void or long suits (see the Bidding Decision Table on p. 20). One can speculate what is in the talon (to exchange one's undesirable cards), but one cannot rely on wishful thinking. Base the decision on w

suit makes it very likely that one can get rid of it through the talon exchange.

If all three players say "Pass", a game of Clop must be played (see next section).

BIDDING EXAMPLE 6

[XX] [XVII] [XVI] [XI] [X] [VI] [V] [II]
[♠P] [◇Q] [♡Q] [♡P] [♣Q] [♣N] [♣8] [♣7]

This hand, although it looks loaded, really has nothing going for it: 8 taroks with one long suit (so effectively 9 taroks) but no honor cards (0 points). This requires a Pass.

Could it possibly win a game of Three? One could deposit the [◇Q], [♡Q], and [♠P] to get rid of two suits and gain 8 points before the game even begins. The remaining singleton [♡P] could be used in a king bluff. This ideal planning may be spoiled by the talon: it is unlikely that none of these three suits will be supplied by the talon. Even without this caveat, three captured kings are not enough to win this hand.

What about the dangers of a Clop? Depending on who leads, this hand would capture maybe one queen and a few value cards because of the numerous taroks, but no more than –20, which is less than a third of the total of 70, in other words, less than the other two players. Again, the conclusion is Pass.

BIDDING EXAMPLE 7

[XVIII] [XIV] [XII] [IX] [VII]
[♠K] [♠10] [♠9] [♠8] [♡1] [♡2] [♣K] [◇K] [◇N] [◇P] [◇4]

With only 5 taroks and no Trio, and in spite of three kings, this is a Pass. With so few taroks one cannot hope to use both long suits for taroking, as one would run out of one's own taroks. One can expect to recover at most four kings

and a queen or two, but 28 points are not enough for a victory. Counting on the talon for support is risky.

Always check your decision by assuming that everybody will Pass. A Clop will hit you with about –30: entire clubs, plus 2 kings and maybe 2 queens, depending on whether or not you are the first to lead with the [♢N]. Still, the number of taroks is too low.

BIDDING EXAMPLE 8

[XVI] [XV] [XIII] [XII] [X] [VII] [VI] [IIII]
[♡2] [♡3] [♠K] [♢N] [♢2] [♣N] [♣8] [♣7]

This is a weak hand: 8 taroks and 1 honor card cannot win more than all spades. Even if we count on depositing [♢N], [♢2], and [♣N] (5 points) and thus capturing both [♢K] and [♢Q] (9 points) with taroks, this only adds up to about 27 points. A game of Clop would cost less: about –13 points for taking all the spades. So, Pass!

Interestingly, a Clop was played in this deal, and this hand would have scored the best of the three players (–18), were it not for an error, which cost him 5 points more. Follow this game as Player Z in Play Example 3 (p. 82).

BIDDING EXAMPLE 9

[J] [XXI] [XX] [IX] [VIII] [V] [I]
[♡P] [♡1] [♡4] [♠10] [♠7] [♢Q] [♢1] [♣10] [♣9]

This is a curious hand: it essentially holds nothing but the Trio, which totals 15 points. With seven taroks and all four suits, of which at most one might be eliminated in the talon exchange, one can expect to win at most the king and queen of the void suit (9 points), which together with the Trio equals 24 points and is not enough for a victory, and the score for a bid of Three would be –21 (= –11 –10). Before you say Pass, however, consider what will happen in a game of Clop, if everyone else also passes. Again, you will suffer about –15 points, plus some cards from the talon,

which is acceptable as it is less than one third of the total (70) points.

As a matter of fact, a Clop was played in this deal, and this hand scored in the middle: –22 points. Follow this game as Player Y in Play Example 3 (p. 82).

BIDDING EXAMPLE 10

[XIX] [XVIII] [XVII] [XIV] [XI] [III]
[♡Q] [♠Q] [♠N] [♠P] [◇K] [◇P] [◇3] [◇4] [♣K] [♣P]

This is a very interesting hand: 6 taroks with one long suit (counting as effectively 7 taroks) and two honor cards. Although the hand is full of face cards, only the two kings can be expected to take tricks (10 points). Assuming one could deposit [♡Q], [♠Q], and [♠N] and take three kings (all but spades), the sum would be 9 + 15 = 24 points, which is too low for a victory. The two black pages would be kept for king bluffs, but one cannot count on it. With only six taroks, two kings and no Trio, you should Pass in spite of the many face cards in the hand.

Before you Pass, you should always consider how you would fare in an eventual Clop. With these many face cards, it may be a dangerous Clop. Surely you may "win" your two kings and their queens (16 points) and possibly the king and queen of hearts, unless you are lucky enough to get a turn and lead with the [♡Q] first. This would add up to a total of 24 points, plus some cards from the talon, which is getting close to 30, at which point it may be cheaper to lose a game of Three than to lose a Clop. Both games are obvious losers, though. In either case you must gamble: either hope to get something of value in the talon and play Three, or Pass and hope that somebody else will bid Three and save you from the Clop. Decide on Pass.

As a matter of fact, a Clop was played in this deal, and this hand scored –25 points, almost as expected. See Player X in Play Example 3 (p. 82). A game of Three would have lost

a little less, but in a Clop all players score negatively, so the relative drop was smaller in this case.

Before solving any problems in this book, deal yourself the actual cards described in the problem. Do not answer them by solely looking at the book. The feel and looks of the cards while making your decisions are important associations for learning. In bidding problems, assume that you are the first bidder unless stated otherwise.

BIDDING PROBLEM[10] 1
What do you bid with this hand?

[J] [XXI] [XIII] [X] [IX] [III]
[♡K] [♡N] [♡2] [♡3] [♠P] [◇N] [◇3] [♣K] [♣Q] [♣N]

BIDDING PROBLEM[11] 2
What do you bid with this hand?

[XX] [XIX] [XVI] [XV] [XIII] [IIII] [I]
[◇K] [◇2] [♣Q] [♣N] [♣P] [♣9] [♣7] [♡P] [♡4]

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[10] Answer: Three. Although this hand has only six taroks (adjusted to 7 because of one long suit), it contains 4 honor cards, and the Player, by exchanging three cards with the talon, could get rid of both kingless suits and obtain a few more taroks, with a little luck.

[11] Answer: Three. This is another example of a borderline case: 7 taroks (adjusted to 8 for the long suit) plus 15 adjusted points (a king, Pagat, and a void suit), but again, the suits are favorable. The Player can deposit both hearts (deposit rule 1) and the king's pip card (deposit rule 3) but keep the long clubs, though kingless, for knocking out opponents' taroks.

## CLOP

If all players Pass, a game of Clop is obligatory. This is a negative game in which all try to win as few cards as possible, so the strategy of playing is inverted. All players are on their own and score as many (negative) points as they collect with their individual tricks. The talon is not exchanged in a game of Clop and remains face down. The six cards from the talon are simply added, one a time, to the first six tricks in the game, and revealed only at that time. One must, therefore, AVOID TAKING (ESPECIALLY) THE FIRST SIX TRICKS, by leading with low or medium cards, as the talon tends to be rich since all players declined to bid.

In a game of Clop, the same rules apply as in a regular game, except:

1. One must top every played card and take every trick, if possible, while still following suit. That means, if you do not have a higher-rank card, you can play a pip card, but if you are void of the suit, you must play a tarok. For example, if a queen is led, one has to take it with a king, if available. If the Mond is played, one has to take it with the Joker, but *Mondfang* is not counted. If the Mond and Joker are played in the same trick, Pagat must be used to take the trick (*emperor's ruse*). On the other hand:

2. One must never lead with the Pagat; it must be used only if it is the last tarok in your hand or if it is the only card that will take the trick – see *emperor's ruse*. A Pagat *Ultimo* does not count, however. For this reason, it is important to count taroks even during the Clop, for example, to AVOID TAROKING when the Pagat is about to be *schmiered*.

3. There are no announcements and challenges.

4. At the end of the game, three open bullets are drawn in the last column of the score sheet, indicating that in the next games the score will be doubled.

The strategy for obtaining a low score is obvious: FEED YOUR MIDDLE-RANK FACE CARDS to the opponents before they do it to you. For example, if you hold a king and a knight, lead with the knight for an opponent to take it with the queen before your opponent leads with the queen for you to take with the king. Similarly, if you hold the Joker and [XX], lead with the [XX] tarok so that the Mond will have to take it before you have to take the Mond with the Joker. The risk is that one of these honor cards is in the talon; in that case you not only take the trick but may also gain that very card when the talon card is *schmiered* to your trick.

If you cannot take the trick, UNLOAD YOUR HIGHEST-VALUE CARD, following suit, of course (this applies to taroks as well). If you can take a trick, USE THE LOWEST-RANK CARD POSSIBLE (this applies to taroks as well) so that the next Player may take the trick. If you are the last Player taking the trick, use your highest tarok, even the Joker (to get rid of it), but the lowest-possible suit card (to minimize points).

In most games, the rank of pip cards is not critical, but in Clop it is often the case, for example, that a ten of spades takes a seven of spades, with the third card being a fat king of hearts, *schmiered* by the third Player. So, PAY ATTENTION TO THE PIP CARDS and lead with the highest card that you can reasonably and safely assume that one of the opponents will take, and dump the highest pip cards first.

For a description of a Clop game, see Play Example 3 on p. 82.